# STATE SCAN

**ODISHA: AN EITHER/OR QUESTION FOR BJD** *PG 19*

**UP: THE GODS OF SMALL JINKS** *PG 20*



**MINORITIES REPORT** Muslims protest against the Waqf Bill in Mumbai, November 2024; (right) a Christian rally in Mumbai, Jul. 11

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MAHARASHTRA/ GOA

# THE HOLY WRIT OF STATUTE

**As Maharashtra and Goa move to enact laws to block 'love jihad' and 'rice bag' conversions, minorities voice a lack of faith in the intent and foresee a chilling effect on society**

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**LOVE JIHAD AND** 'rice bag' conversions are an odd pair of slogans. The Church was party to coining the first charge against Muslims, but continues to find itself stalked by the second, as the recent arrest of two nuns in Chhattisgarh showed. The two sources of incrimination now get fused all over again as BJP-ruled Maharashtra and Goa—the latter one-quarter Christian—prepare to bring in anti-conversion laws.

Their objective: to prevent change of faith induced via 'fraudulent' means. Given the general run of things, minority groups say they have reason to fear the law may be misused to vilify and target them, and warn against the ongoing 'Hindutva creep' into the realm of sanctified law.

## RISING TENSION

It's not come out of the blue. BJP leaders in Maharashtra—fisheries and ports minister Nitesh Rane, for one—have been campaigning for an anti-conversion law. Christian groups across the state had been driven to protest in mid-July when party MLA Gopichand Padalkar offered up to Rs 11 lakh as bounty for Christian pastors allegedly proselytising among his OBC Dhangar (shepherd) community. An anti-conversion law